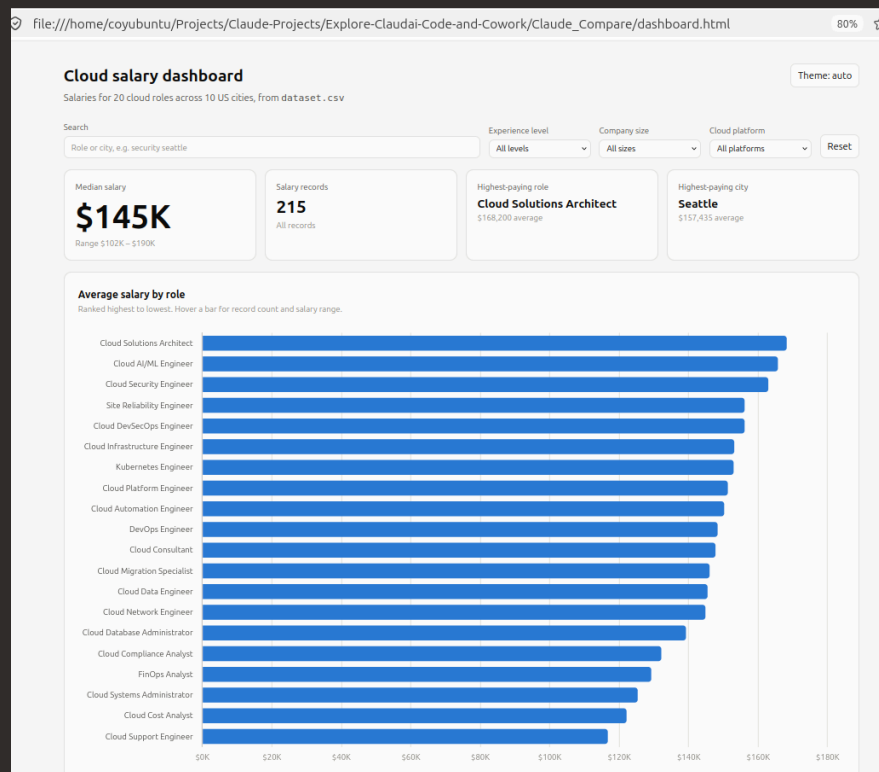




EXPLORE CLAUDE.AI, CODE, AND COWORK

By Emmanuel Apilado | September 2026



Introducing Today's Project!

In this project, I'm going to explore Claude.ai, Claude Code, and Cowork by completing a different task with each one, using cloud job salary data to see firsthand when to reach for which tool. This will help me to understand these different tools that Claude offers which will be helpful for me in the long run to be more efficient in what I do as a DevOps Engineer.

Key tools and concepts

The key tools I used include Claude.ai, Claude Code and Cowork and some command line navigation. I also learnt how to be resilient to accomplish the project using a different environment (Windows) as my go to OS (Ubuntu) using Oracle VM Box got a dead end error and it impedes me to accomplishing step 4 for Cowork.

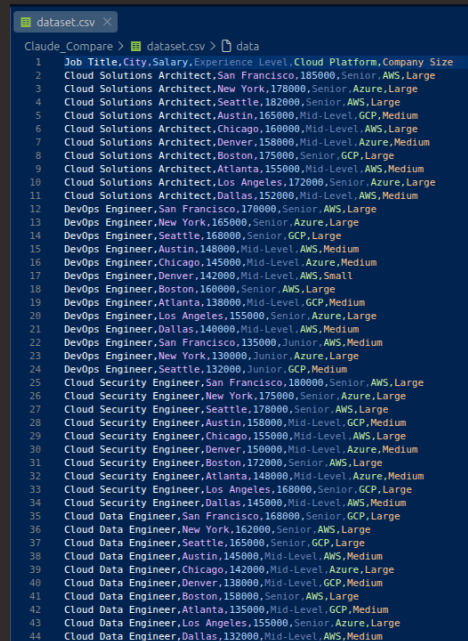
Key concepts I learnt includes the proper use of these tools to utilize its power for the projects I'll be working on and make my work fast and efficient.

Challenges and wins

I did this project today to learn how to use all the tools for Claud.ai, Claude Code and Cowork. Another skill I want to learn is

Setting Up with Claude.ai and the Dataset

In this step, I'll be signing in to Claude.ai as I already have a subscription and download the cloud salary dataset. I'll create a project directory named Claude_Compare where the cloud salary dataset will be stored. The Claude_Compare directory will be the root directory for this project.



```
dataset.csv
Claude_Compare > dataset.csv > data
1 Job Title,City,Salary,Experience,Cloud Platform,Company Size
2 Cloud Solutions Architect,San Francisco,185000,Senior,AWS,Large
3 Cloud Solutions Architect,New York,178000,Senior,Azure,Large
4 Cloud Solutions Architect,Seattle,182000,Senior,AWS,Large
5 Cloud Solutions Architect,Austin,165000,Mid-Level,GCP,Medium
6 Cloud Solutions Architect,Chicago,160000,Mid-Level,AWS,Large
7 Cloud Solutions Architect,Denver,158000,Mid-Level,Azure,Medium
8 Cloud Solutions Architect,Boston,175000,Senior,GCP,Large
9 Cloud Solutions Architect,Atlanta,155000,Mid-Level,AWS,Medium
10 Cloud Solutions Architect,Los Angeles,172000,Senior,Azure,Large
11 Cloud Solutions Architect,Dallas,152000,Mid-Level,AWS,Medium
12 DevOps Engineer,San Francisco,170000,Senior,AWS,Large
13 DevOps Engineer,New York,165000,Senior,Azure,Large
14 DevOps Engineer,Seattle,168000,Senior,GCP,Large
15 DevOps Engineer,Austin,148000,Mid-Level,AWS,Medium
16 DevOps Engineer,Chicago,145000,Mid-Level,Azure,Medium
17 DevOps Engineer,Denver,142000,Mid-Level,AWS,Small
18 DevOps Engineer,Boston,160000,Senior,AWS,Large
19 DevOps Engineer,Atlanta,138000,Mid-Level,GCP,Medium
20 DevOps Engineer,Los Angeles,156000,Senior,Azure,Large
21 DevOps Engineer,Dallas,140000,Mid-Level,AWS,Medium
22 DevOps Engineer,San Francisco,135000,Junior,AWS,Medium
23 DevOps Engineer,New York,130000,Junior,Azure,Large
24 DevOps Engineer,Seattle,132000,Junior,GCP,Medium
25 Cloud Security Engineer,San Francisco,180000,Senior,AWS,Large
26 Cloud Security Engineer,New York,175000,Senior,Azure,Large
27 Cloud Security Engineer,Seattle,178000,Senior,AWS,Large
28 Cloud Security Engineer,Austin,158000,Mid-Level,GCP,Medium
29 Cloud Security Engineer,Chicago,155000,Mid-Level,AWS,Large
30 Cloud Security Engineer,Denver,150000,Mid-Level,Azure,Medium
31 Cloud Security Engineer,Boston,172000,Senior,AWS,Large
32 Cloud Security Engineer,Atlanta,148000,Mid-Level,Azure,Medium
33 Cloud Security Engineer,Los Angeles,168000,Senior,GCP,Large
34 Cloud Security Engineer,Dallas,145000,Mid-Level,AWS,Medium
35 Cloud Data Engineer,San Francisco,168000,Senior,GCP,Large
36 Cloud Data Engineer,New York,162000,Senior,AWS,Large
37 Cloud Data Engineer,Seattle,165000,Senior,GCP,Large
38 Cloud Data Engineer,Austin,145000,Mid-Level,AWS,Medium
39 Cloud Data Engineer,Chicago,142000,Mid-Level,Azure,Large
40 Cloud Data Engineer,Denver,138000,Mid-Level,GCP,Medium
41 Cloud Data Engineer,Boston,158000,Senior,AWS,Large
42 Cloud Data Engineer,Atlanta,135000,Mid-Level,GCP,Medium
43 Cloud Data Engineer,Los Angeles,155000,Senior,Azure,Large
44 Cloud Data Engineer,Dallas,132000,Mid-Level,AWS,Medium
```

Understanding the data

The cloud salary dataset contains cloud roles, location, salary, tenureship (experience level), cloud platform and company size. We can analyze the data to visualize, organize create charts and a dashboard out of this.

Exploring Cloud Salaries with Claude.ai

In this step I'll upload the cloud salary data and use Claud.ai to explore the data conversationally via chat and generate interactive charts with Artifacts.

How do salaries compare across AWS, Azure, and GCP roles?

Summarize salaries by cloud platform >

The three platforms pay almost the same. The average salaries are within about \$4,000 of each other, and the gaps shrink further when you compare the same experience level.

Platform	Roles	Avg salary	Range
GCP	63	\$147,873	\$105k-\$190k
AWS	93	\$146,667	\$102k-\$185k
Azure	59	\$143,661	\$108k-\$178k

At the same experience level, the gap is small:

Level	AWS	Azure	GCP
Senior	\$161.9k	\$160.8k	\$161.7k
Mid-level	\$138.6k	\$136.1k	\$139.3k
Junior	\$124.0k	\$122.0k	\$124.8k

Senior pay is essentially identical across all three. At the mid and junior levels, AWS and GCP are within about \$1,000 of each other, and Azure trails by roughly \$2,000-\$3,000.

GCP's slight lead in the overall average comes mostly from its mix of roles. Nearly half of its entries (48%) are senior, compared with 42% for AWS and 36% for Azure. Azure's lower average is partly the same effect in reverse, since it has the smallest share of senior roles.

AWS is by far the most common platform, with 93 of the 215 roles, about 43% of the file.

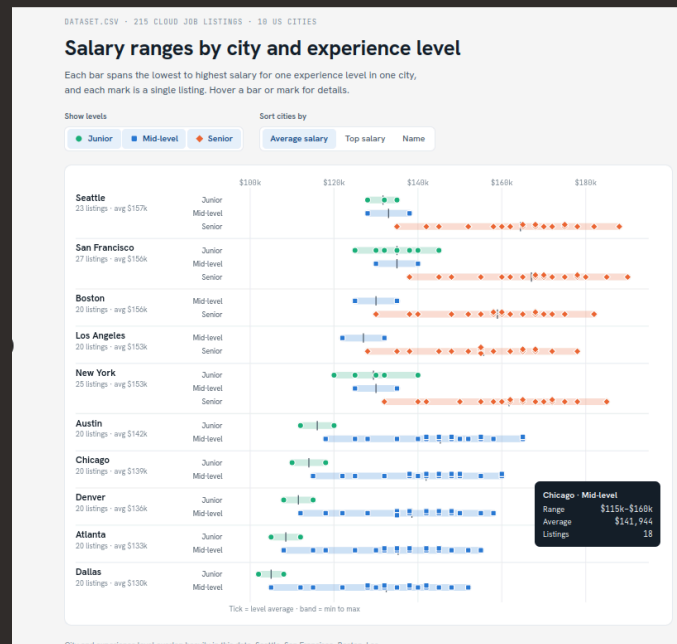
Choosing a cloud platform barely affects pay in this data. Experience level (about a \$38,000 gap between junior and senior) and job title (about \$50,000 between the top and bottom roles) matter far more.

Insights from the data

I learned that the highest paying roles are Cloud Solutions Architect, Cloud AI/ML Engineer, Cloud Security Engineer, Cloud DevSecOps Engineer and Site Reliability Engineer. And the cities that offer the higher salaries are Seattle, San Francisco and Boston. This is a good presentation as Claude.ai arranged the data from my inquiry in descending order

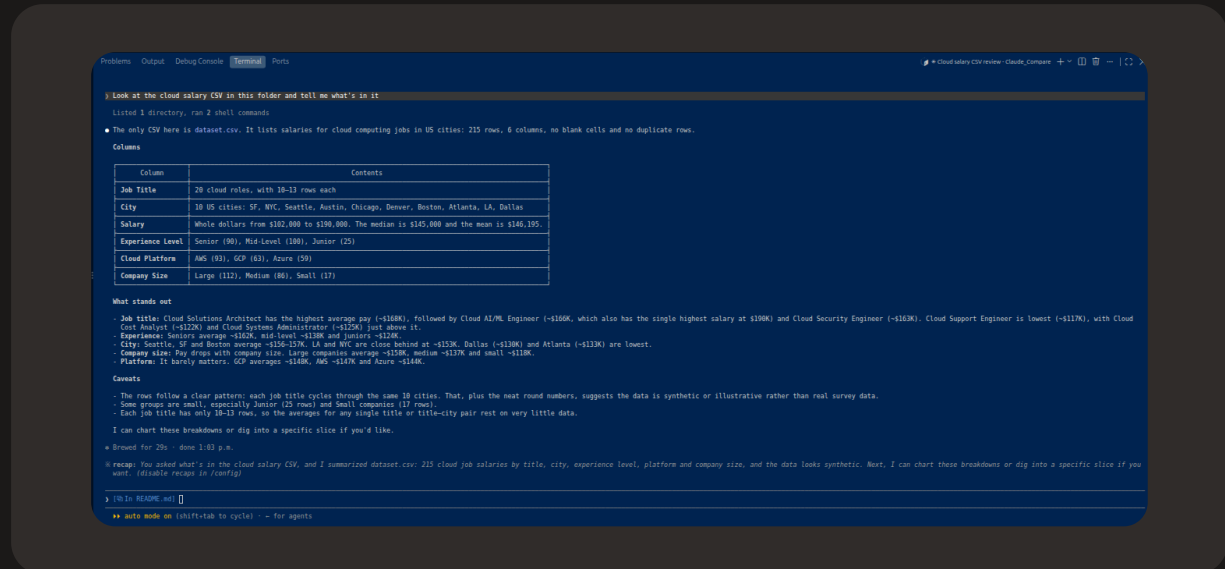
Generating Interactive Charts with Artifacts

Artifacts are interactive visual outputs that Claude.ai renders live in your browser. They can be charts, code snippets, documents or even a small application. They are useful because you can interact with it, download it or iterate with follow-up prompts.



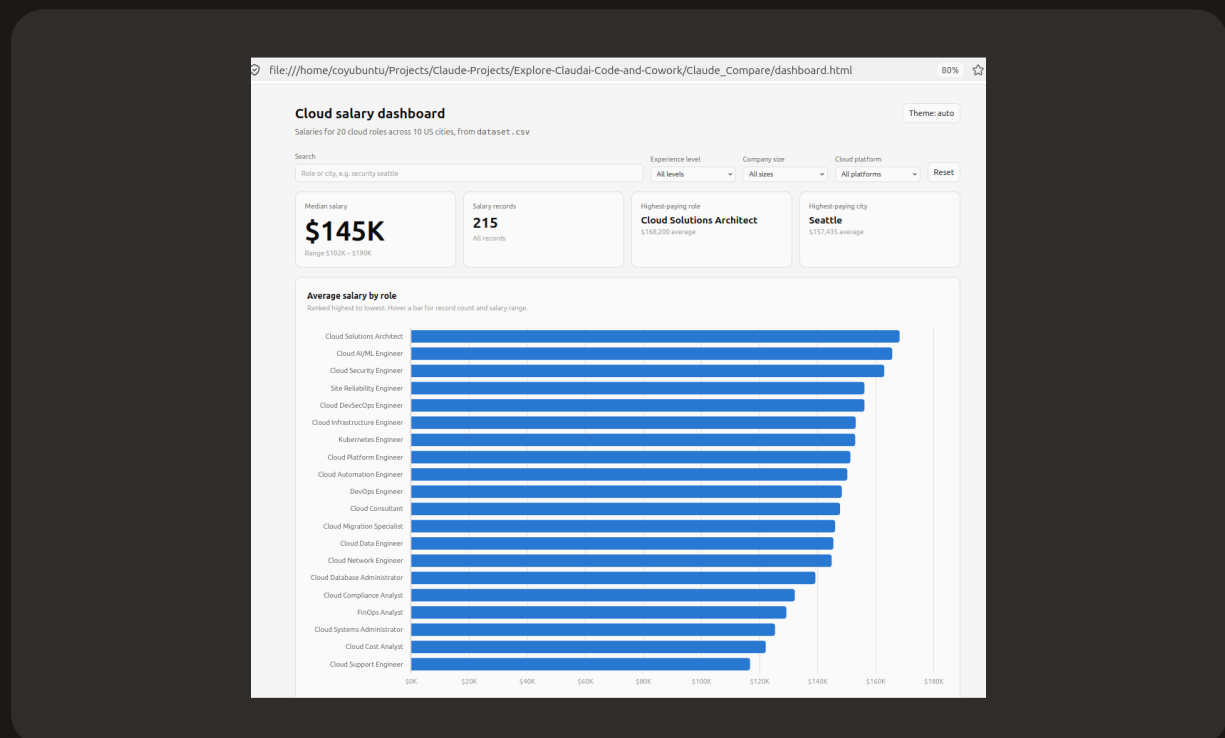
Building a Dashboard with Claude Code

In this step, I'm installing Claude Code to explore the salary data in the terminal and build an interactive dashboard with Chart.js charts.



How Claude Code works differently

The key difference is that Claude Code build or edit files (or multiple files) directly from your computer file system. While Claude.ai, you upload it in the browser and Claude.ai will explore the file and you can have an interactive conversation via chat with Claude.ai to analyze the data and produce an Artifact for visual reference.



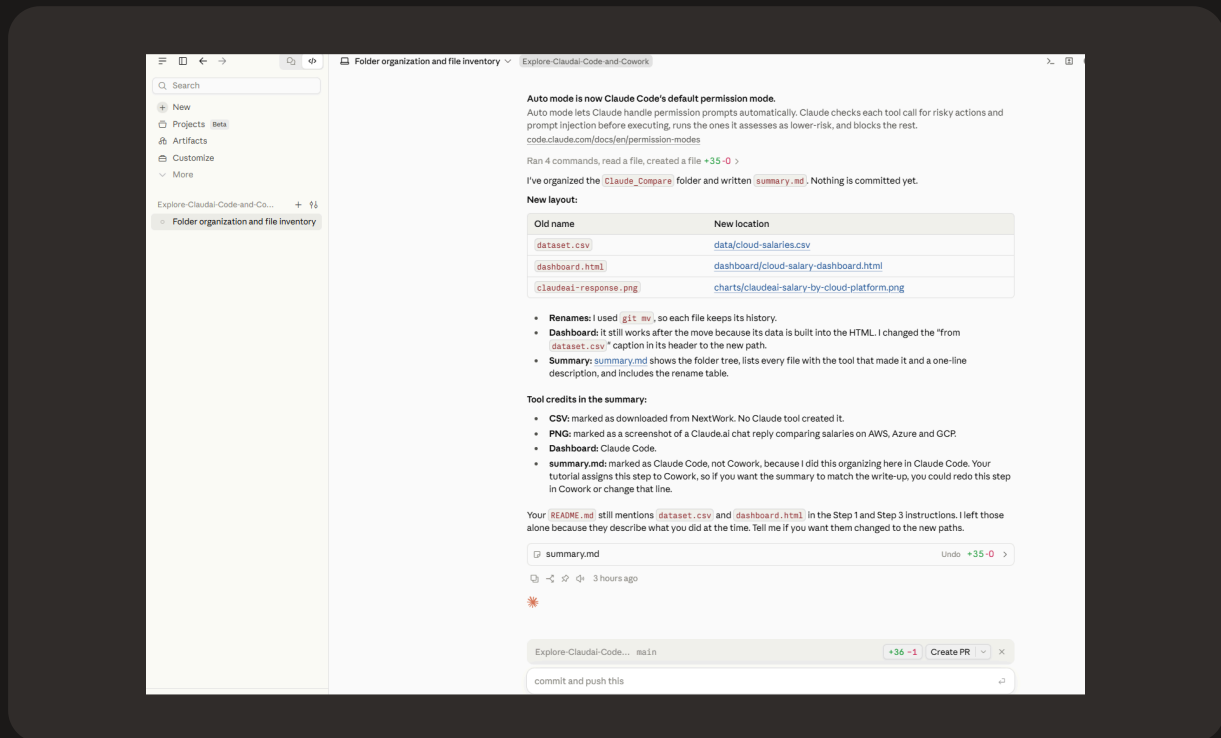
The interactive dashboard

Claude Code created or build the interactive html dashboard for me permanently in accordance to my prompt in the terminal and the standalone HTML file (dashboard.html) was saved directly in my project directory.

This is different from Claude.ai because the interactive charts are rendered as "Artifacts" in a dedicated panel on the right side of my web browser. The visual charts are only available during the chat session but once the session is closed, the chart cannot be opened offline or accessed directly on my computer. If you aren't login to Claude or doesn't have internet connection, you can't open or use the chart but you can download the code block from the Artifact.

Organizing Everything with Claude Cowork

In this step, I'm using Cowork to organize my files in my Claude_Compare/ directory. We'll share the local files inside this directory to Claude Desktop where it has the built-in agent called "Cowork" that will directly work on my files. I'll just describe what I want, and Cowork will handle the rest.



What makes Cowork unique

Cowork and Claude code both work on files on your computer but it serves a different purpose.

Cowork is best in managing, renaming and organizing your local files and it is run in Claude Desktop app. You need to explicitly share your local folder to Cowork and grant it access to that folder.

Claude Code on the other hand runs in the terminal and is best in "executing code" (build it) on your local/working directory.

Claude.ai is for conversational analysis. You can upload your file, ask questions in plain English, and receive interactive visual outputs called "Artifacts" making it best for data exploration.

```

1  # Claude_Compare - Project Summary
2
3  One cloud salary dataset, explored with three Claude tools: Claude.ai for conversational analysis, Claude Code for a local dash
4  folder.
5
6  ## Folder structure
7  ***
8  Claude_Compare/
9  ├── charts/
10     └── claudeai-salary-by-cloud-platform.png
11  ├── dashboard/
12     └── cloud-salary-dashboard.html
13  ├── data/
14     └── cloud-salaries.csv
15  └── summary.md
16  ***
17
18  ## Files
19
20  | File | Created by | Description |
21  |-----|-----|-----|
22  | `data/cloud-salaries.csv` | None (downloaded from NextWork) | Source dataset of 215 cloud job listings with job title, city,
23  company size. |
24  | `charts/claudeai-salary-by-cloud-platform.png` | Claude.ai (screenshot of a chat response) | Claude.ai's answer comparing ave
25  and by experience level. |
26  | `dashboard/cloud-salary-dashboard.html` | Claude Code | Interactive Chart.js dashboard showing average salary by role, a city
27  | `summary.md` | Claude Code | This document: the folder layout, plus each file's origin and contents. |
28
29  ## Renames
30
31  | Original name | New location |
32  |-----|-----|
33  | `dataset.csv` | `data/cloud-salaries.csv` |
34  | `claudeai-response.png` | `charts/claudeai-salary-by-cloud-platform.png` |
35  | `dashboard.html` | `dashboard/cloud-salary-dashboard.html` |
36
37  The dashboard embeds its data, so it still works after the move. Open `dashboard/cloud-salary-dashboard.html` in a browser.

```

The organized project folder

The summary document lists every file, and it provides one-line description of what it contains. This is useful because the summary.md document gives us useful information/details about this folder where it can be useful for future references.

Building a Claude Tool Cheat Sheet

In this project extension, I will create a personal decision framework -- a cheat sheet that maps each Claude tool to the situations where it works best and I decided to use Claude Code as my go-to tool to build the cheat sheet for this secret mission.

```
Problems Output Debug Console Terminal Ports

> Create a file called which-claude.sh that helps me decide which Claude tool to use. The script should:

1. Ask me "What do you need to do?" and show these options:
  a) Explore data or ask questions
  b) Write code or build something
  c) Organize files or automate tasks
2. Based on my answer, recommend the right tool with a one-line explanation:
  - a - Claude.ai: best for uploading files, asking questions, and generating Artifacts
  - b - Claude Code: best for writing code, reading files, and building projects
  - c - Cowork: best for organizing folders, renaming files, and hands-off tasks
3. After showing the recommendation, print a quick tip for getting started with that tool.

Make the script executable.

• Write(which-claude.sh)
  Wrote 35 lines to which-claude.sh
  1 #!/usr/bin/env bash
  2 # which-claude.sh - helps you decide which Claude tool to use.
  3
  4 echo "What do you need to do?"
  5 echo "  a) Explore data or ask questions"
  6 echo "  b) Write code or build something"
  7 echo "  c) Organize files or automate tasks"
  8 echo
  9
 10 while true; do
  .. +25 lines

• Bash(chmod +x which-claude.sh && ls -l which-claude.sh && echo B | ./which-claude.sh && printf '\n\n' | ./which-claude.sh)
  - rxrxvrxr-x 1 coyubuntu coyubuntu 1186 Sep 26 21:25 which-claude.sh
  What do you need to do?
  a) Explore data or ask questions
  .. +15 lines
  1 file changed (binary, mode only or too large to show)
  What this command changed: a convenience view, not a review or audit of the command)
  Allowed by auto mode classifier

• I created which-claude.sh and made it executable. Run it with ./which-claude.sh.

It asks "What do you need to do?" and lists options a, b and c. Your answer gets the matching recommendation and one-line explanation, then a getting-started tip:
- a - Claude.ai: drag a file into the chat and ask Claude to summarize or chart it.
- b - Claude Code: go to your project folder, run claude, then type /init to create a CLAUDE.md.
- c - Cowork: open the Claude desktop app, switch to Cowork, give it access to a folder and describe the result you want.

I tested it by piping in answers. Uppercase works (B gave the Claude Code recommendation). Jump to bottom (ctrl+End) (x) got an error message and a second chance before a was accepted. Because the answers

> [In README.md] Submit and push it
  auto mode on (shift+tab to cycle) -- for agents
```

My decision framework

I chose to use Claude Code because I'm more of a command line person. My rule of thumb for each tool is to use it appropriately to utilize the power of these tools in accordance to the need of my project.

If I need to build a code, then use Claude Code. If it's to analyze a file and make it interactive visual, then use Claude.ai. And if it's to manage files, rename them and organize it, then use Cowork.

Wrapping Up

This project took me approximately 1.5 hrs and the challenging part was just really transitioning from my Ubuntu to Windows machine on step 4 Cowork as I hit a dead end for the error since I won't be able to install Claude Desktop due to VM limitation in regards to Hardware Virtualization needs to be turned on. But I still was able to finish the project.